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ANCA-WR and Northern California Chapter Advocate for Legislation in Sacramento

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acramento, CA – On March 10th and 11th, representatives from the Armenian National Committee of America – Western Region joined the ANCA Northern California chapter for a two-day advocacy round in Sacramento. ANCA-NorCal is a regional chapter of ANCA-WR that represents local chapters ANCA San Francisco, ANCA Silicon Valley, and ANCA Sacramento.

The delegation, which included ANCA-WR Chair Oshin Harootoonian, Government Affairs Director Ruben Karapetian, Government Affairs Coordinator Sonia Meroian, and ANCA-NorCal Coordinator Henry Agajanov, met with 22 legislative offices in the State Capitol to discuss key legislative items and issues pertinent to the Armenian-American community in California. The meetings primarily focused on advocating for two key legislative initiatives supported by ANCA-WR, bills AB-91 and SB-472, and the Armenian-American community's relief efforts in the aftermath of the devastating Los Angeles fires.

Assembly Bill 91 – MENA Inclusion Act

A major legislative focus, Assembly Bill 91 was introduced on January 6th by Assemblymember John Harabedian, who also serves as Chair of the Armenian Legislative Caucus Foundation. This bicameral, bipartisan coalition—now the largest it has ever been—consists of 50 lawmakers dedicated to promoting Armenian-American interests in the California State Legislature. AB-91 would mandate state and local agencies in California that collect demographic data to expand their classifications to include major Middle Eastern, North African, and other transnational regional groups in all official public forms and documentation. Such agencies would also be required to report the data they've collected to the US Census Bureau prior to each centennial survey. As part of the bill's effort, Armenians would be counted separately alongside 30 other distinct groups indigenous to the region and its surrounding area.

Armenian-Americans are currently grouped under the "white" category in demographic data, which has led to significant underrepresentation for the community both in California and across the United States due to the label's broad parameters and the lack of distinct ethnic and national sub-categories attributed to it in most public forms. This 'data invisibility' can limit Armenian-Americans' access to vital resources, including state and federal funding, scholarships, and grants for community-based initiatives such as cultural programs and events. AB-91 aims to mitigate these disparities by ensuring a more precise, inclusive, and representative classification of Armenian-Americans and other historically undercounted communities within California's diverse population. The size and strength of our local community add weight to the urgency and importance of this effort, as California is home to the largest Armenian community in the United States and also represents the second-largest Armenian diaspora in the world. The bill is scheduled to be heard in the Assembly Judiciary Committee on March 25th, 2025, at 8 AM PST. We encourage members of the Armenian-American community to watch the live hearing.

Senate Bill 472 – Holocaust and Genocide Education Grant Program

Although the Armenian Genocide is included in California's Curriculum Frameworks and Instructional Materials, its instruction varies widely across classrooms statewide. Senate Bill 472, introduced by Senator Henry Stern with co-sponsorship from Senators Benjamin Allen and Scott Wiener, aims to address this inconsistency by establishing the 'Holocaust and Genocide Education Grant Program'. Pending a final budget determination by the state legislature, this program would allocate a dedicated funding stream from the State Treasury to local educational agencies in California with the stated aim of enhancing curricula and training educators to effectively teach about the Holocaust and other genocides in public schools, which would include the Armenian Genocide. Advocating for the expansion of Armenian Genocide education has been a longstanding priority for the ANCA-WR and the wider Armenian-American community, and we remain committed to ensuring SB-472 secures the necessary support in both chambers. No

hearing has been scheduled for this bill as of March 14th, 2025.

Legislative Meetings

From Monday, March 10th, to Tuesday, March 11th, ANCA-WR and ANCA-NorCal met with the following offices:

California State Senate:

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Senator Christopher Cabaldon (D-SD-3)

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Senator Sasha Renée Peréz (D-SD-25)

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Senator Henry Stern (D-SD-27)

California State Assembly:

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Assemblymember Lisa Calderon (D-AD-56)

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Assemblymember Jessica Caloza (D-AD-52)

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Assemblymember Mike Fong (D-AD-49)

*

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-AD-46)

*

Assemblymember John Harabedian (D-AD-41)

*

Assemblymember Josh Hoover (R-AD-7)

*

Assemblymember Josh Lowenthal (D-AD-69)

*

Assemblymember Al Muratsuchi (D-AD-66)

*

Assemblymember Liz Ortega (D-AD-20)

*

Assemblymember Pilar Schiavo (D-AD-40)

*

Assemblymember Kate Sanchez (R-AD-71)

*

Assemblymember Nick Schultz (D-AD-44)

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Assemblymember Catherine Stefani (D-AD-19)

*

Assemblymember David Tangipa (R-AD-8)

*

Assemblymember Rich Chavez Zbur (D-AD-51)

*

Assemblymember Blanca E. Rubio (D-AD-48)

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Assemblymember Mark Gonzalez (D-AD-54)

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Assemblymember Heath Flora (R-AD-9)

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Assemblymember Buffy Wicks (D-AD-14)

"We have many allies in the California State Legislature, and we are grateful for their strong support of our communities across the state. The California Armenian Legislative Caucus is the largest it's ever been at 50 members strong. We must maintain our momentum as a community to ensure our priorities and concerns are heard," stated Oshin Harootoonian, Chair of ANCA-WR Board of Directors.

The ANCA-WR office, in coordination with our regional chapter in Northern California, continues to monitor legislative priorities and issues pertinent to the Armenian-American community in the Golden State. In the coming weeks, we hope to join more members of the California State Legislature in local meetings at their district offices.

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